The seeds of INDIA were sown over the past nine years. When the BJP came to power in 2014, the Communist Party of India noted that it was not a mere change of government, but a threat to the basic fibre of our country and Constitution. The CPI was of the opinion that the unity of all secular–democratic forces was imperative to remove the BJP from power and to protect democracy. The urgency for the formation of INDIA was impressed upon us all by the millions of Indians suffering in the RSS–BJP rule. Our shared concern for the people's welfare convinced us that we must work unitedly. Different political parties and social organizations sharing and coming together at the Bharat Jodo Yatra platform gave a further fillip to the process of uniting the Opposition.

Now we need to do much more to channelize the positive spirit of unity and the Yatra. For that, we need to keep posing a credible vision to counter the majoritarian politics espoused by the RSS–BJP. Along with that, we need to keep accommodating each other's interests to foster mutual trust—both until May 2024 and beyond—to protect our country and our people from RSS–BJP misrule. And, most importantly, we need to offer a tangible ideological counter to the RSS–BJP. This is not just in the form of lofty ideals, but grassroots movements and programmes. In this context, the Communist Party of India is taking a greater initiative to strengthen the class and mass organizations representing different sections of our people. The artificial divides being created by the RSS–BJP have to be bridged and people will have to be united in protecting our Constitution and the legacy of our freedom movement. Without doing that, we will not be fighting majoritarianism and cronyism in India in a meaningful manner.

Dr Ambedkar warned the nation about the life of contradictions we would be entering when we inaugurated our Republic. He said, 'In politics we will have equality and in social and economic life we will have inequality.' This has become more relevant today. The RSS–BJP have only furthered the contradictions of caste, class and gender. The challenges India faces today necessitate a revolutionary effort by all secular and democratic forces. As the Yatra's key message suggests, we need to unite to save India. In the national interest, we must stand united. Only then can we re-establish